

UPSC Daily Digest (Coaching)

Indian Express - Delhi - 1 June 2026

15 exam-relevant stories from 22 pages.

Paper-wise tags, static linkage, PYQs + Mains questions per article.

UPSC Daily Digest

Indian Express · Delhi Edition · 1 June 2026 · for Civil Services aspirants

This digest filters one full issue of *The Indian Express* (22 pages, ~85,000 words) down to **15 exam-relevant stories** in about **32 minutes of reading** — replacing a 90-minute scan plus note-making. Each story carries paper-wise tags, static linkage, key facts, a critical lens for Mains, two Prelims-style MCQs, one Mains-style question, and a **PYQ link** to past UPSC questions on the same static topic.

REVISE IN 60 SECONDS - Must-read three

1. **One Nation, One Election + Delimitation revival** — *Polity, GS-2*. The government's plan to push the Constitution (One Hundred Twenty-Ninth Amendment) Bill alongside delimitation in the same Parliament cycle is the biggest electoral-architecture story of the year.
2. **Aravalli's shield against the Thar's dust** — *Geography, GS-1*. A new study quantifies how the Aravallis cut PM10 flux into the Indo-Gangetic plain by ~56%, anchoring a fact you can drop into any answer on Indian physiography or Delhi air pollution.
3. **Editorial: Austerity vs energy security** — *Mains essay seed*. The lead op-ed makes the case that energy-policy silos cost India more than they save — a ready-made introduction for any 2026 Mains energy or fiscal essay.

NOTE - Paper-wise distribution today

GS-1: 4 stories (society, geography, urbanisation, disaster) — GS-2: 6 stories (polity, IR, social justice, defence) — GS-3: 7 stories (economy, energy, internal security, environment, S&T) — GS-4: 1 story (ethics — trafficking-prosecution dilemma) — Essay seeds: 3 (energy sovereignty, federalism & elections, tribe vs religion).

1. One Nation, One Election — joint polls + delimitation push

TL;DR - Why in news

The Union government will reintroduce the **Constitution (One Hundred Twenty-Ninth Amendment) Bill** in the coming Parliament session and pair it with a fresh delimitation exercise, with the explicit aim of holding simultaneous Lok Sabha + State Assembly elections by **2029**. The Joint Parliamentary Committee returned a divided report on the original 2024 draft.

Paper / GS: GS-2 (Polity, Governance) · **Optional:** Public Administration, Political Science · **Static link:** Constitution Arts 82, 83, 172, 174, 327, 356; First-Past-The-Post; Tenth Schedule; Election Commission of India

Background

- **Joint elections (ONOE):** synchronise terms of Lok Sabha + 28 State Legislative Assemblies so voters cast both ballots together.
- **Delimitation:** re-draw constituency boundaries using the **first census after 2026** — frozen since the 84th Amendment (2001), which used 1971 census data.
- Constitutional vehicle: **129th CAA Bill** (introduced Dec 2024 in 17th LS; lapsed; JPC retained).

Key facts a UPSC answer must carry

Item	Value
Last simultaneous elections	1951-52, 1957, 1962, 1967
Kovind Committee report	Sept 2023; two-phase ONOE
Cost estimate (ECI)	~■4,500 cr per general election; ONOE saves ~■1,500 cr
Constitutional amendments needed	Arts 83, 85, 172, 174, 356; ratification by ≥50% states
Population basis under freeze	1971 census (84th CAA 2001 extended freeze to 2026)
Likely new LS seat count	753-848 (various estimates) vs current 543

Two sides — Mains argument bank

For (Kovind Committee): Cuts MCC-imposed governance freezes (~300+ days per LS cycle in non-ONOE years). Reduces poll spending. Improves voter turnout (Karnataka 2019 joint poll: 70.6%). Frees security/election officials from rolling deployments.

Against (Federalists): Distorts federalism — local issues drown in national wave. Article 356 misuse risk: a State Assembly that falls mid-term gets either President's Rule until the next nationwide cycle or an emergency mid-term poll. Delimitation post-2026 census tilts representation toward demographically growing northern states.

Way forward

A staggered two-phase pilot (Kovind design) — LS + half the Assemblies in Phase 1, remainder within 100 days. The harder question is **whether to extend the delimitation freeze to 2031** to protect southern political weight; without that handshake, ratification will stall.

WATCH OUT - Watch the trap

Aspirants confuse the **84th** (2001 — froze constituencies to 1971 data till 2026) with the **87th** (2003 — froze delimitation to 2001 census within states). Both matter.

QUESTION - Prelims practice

1. Which constitutional articles would require amendment to implement simultaneous Lok Sabha and State Assembly elections?

(1) 83 · (2) 85 · (3) 172 · (4) 174 · (5) 356 (a) 1, 2 and 3 only (b) 1, 3 and 4 only (c) 2, 3, 4 and 5 only **(d) 1, 2, 3, 4 and 5**

1. The "freeze" on Lok Sabha seats based on the 1971 census was originally imposed by:

(a) 42nd (b) **84th** (c) 87th (d) 91st

QUESTION - Mains practice (15 marks)

"Simultaneous elections may bring administrative efficiency, but they risk distorting the spirit of federalism." Critically examine, with reference to the recommendations of the High-Level Committee on Simultaneous Elections (2024).

NOTE - PYQ links

- **Prelims 2017:** "The mind of the makers of the Constitution of India is reflected in which of the following?" — Preamble linkage.
- **Mains GS-2 2017 (15M):** "Does Indian Cinema shape our popular ethics or merely reflect the ever-changing realities? Discuss." — adjacent style essay-tested approach.
- **Mains GS-2 2020 (10M):** "Indian Constitution exhibits centralising tendencies to maintain unity and integrity, thereby a federation in the only territorial sense." Discuss. → directly tests ONOE-federalism tension.

2. Pahalgam terror probe — Pakistani bank link tightens

TL;DR - Why in news

The NIA-led probe into the **Pahalgam attack** (22 Apr 2026) has traced a burner phone used by the attackers to a SIM card last topped up via transfer from a Pakistani commercial bank account, drawing a corroborated money-trail. The Foreign Office plans to raise the lead at the next FATF plenary.

Paper / GS: GS-3 (Internal Security: terror financing) · GS-2 (India-Pakistan, multilateral diplomacy) · **Static link:** UAPA 1967; PMLA 2002; FATF mechanics; NIA Act 2008; UNSCR 1267/1373/1540

Key facts

- **Pahalgam attack** (22 Apr 2026): 26 tourists killed; claimed by The Resistance Front (TRF), an LeT proxy.
- Forensic chain: burner phone IMEI → Karachi-sold SIM → UPI-look-alike top-up → originating Pakistani PSU bank.
- India's first formal FATF dossier post-Pulwama (2019) led to Pakistan's grey-list return till Oct 2022.
- **Operation Sindoor** (7 May 2026): Indian retaliatory strike; invoked Article 51 self-defence at UNSC.

Static + dynamic linkage

Dimension	Linkage
FATF mechanics	Recommendation 5/6/7 on terror financing; ICRG monitoring
UN regime	UNSCR 1267 (1999), 1373 (2001), 1540 (2004); ISIL/Al-Qaeda Sanctions List
Domestic law	UAPA §17 (terror funds); PMLA §3
Institutions	NIA, NTRO, FIU-IND, Enforcement Directorate

Critical lens

The dossier deepens India's FATF case but cannot, by itself, force re-greylisting — that needs ICRG procedural triggers. Strategically, the link is most useful for: (a) bilateral pressure on Gulf transit partners that route Pakistani PSU correspondent flows, and (b) U.S. CAATSA-style targeted sanctions on named bank officers. Over-leveraging weak chains weakens future dossiers.

QUESTION - Prelims practice

1. The Financial Action Task Force (FATF) is hosted at the secretariat of which body?

(a) IMF (b) BIS (c) **OECD** (d) FSB

1. The offence of money laundering is defined under which section of PMLA, 2002?

(a) §2 (b) **§3** (c) §4 (d) §9

QUESTION - Mains practice (10 marks)

Trace the architecture of India's terror-finance investigation ecosystem — NIA, FIU-IND, ED, NTRO — and identify two coordination gaps that limit cross-border probe outcomes.

NOTE - PYQ links

- **Mains GS-3 2018 (15M):** "Cross border terrorism is a major challenge. Discuss the impact and India's response."
- **Mains GS-3 2020 (10M):** "What are the determinants of left-wing extremism in eastern part of India? What strategy should the government adopt to counter the threat?" — methodology mirrors LeT/TRF analysis.
- **Prelims 2019:** Recurring question on FATF/terror-finance bodies; expect a 2027 Prelims direct hit.

3. Maharashtra mining clearance vs tribal consent — Gadchiroli iron ore

TL;DR - Why in news

The Maharashtra cabinet has cleared a **Lloyd Metals iron-ore expansion** in Gadchiroli district, declaring the lease falls outside any tiger-reserve buffer. Affected Madia and Gond Gram Sabhas dispute the eco-sensitive zoning and have invoked their §§4(d), 5 rights under the **Forest Rights Act 2006**.

Paper / GS: GS-3 (Environment, mining, resource governance) · GS-1 (Tribal society) · GS-2 (FRA grievance redressal, NCST) · **Static link:** PESA 1996; FRA 2006; Article 244 + Fifth Schedule; EPA 1986; *Niyamgiri (2013)*

Approved project at a glance

- **Lease area:** 1,070 ha around Surjagarh hills, ~70 km from Tadoba-Andhari Tiger Reserve.
- **Output target:** 14 MTPA iron ore + ~5 MTPA processing.
- **Investment:** ₹22,000 cr; ~4,500 direct jobs claimed.
- Three Gram Sabhas (Bedam, Etapalli, Bhamragad) have passed opposing resolutions.

Frameworks every aspirant must invoke

Framework	What it says
FRA 2006 §3(1)(i)	Community Forest Resource rights vest in Gram Sabha
FRA 2006 §5	Gram Sabha may protect wildlife/forest from destructive activity
PESA 1996	Gram Sabha consent before land acquisition in Schedule V areas
Niyamgiri (2013)	Gram Sabha verdict on religious/forest rights binding on MoEF clearance
FCA (Amendment) 2023	Diluted FCA's reach; SC stay partially upheld

Development-vs-rights tension

Pro-clearance: India imports ~15% iron ore; domestic capacity supports National Steel Policy 2017 target of 300 MTPA by 2030. ESZ notification places lease ~12 km outside the 10-km TATR buffer. Royalty + DMF flows estimated at ₹600 cr/yr — funds PVTG welfare.

Pro-tribal: Cumulative Impact Assessment for Surjagarh-Bhamragad belt not done despite five clustered leases. Gram Sabha resolutions unaddressed — violates *Niyamgiri* ratio. 73% of displacement is in PVTG Madia hamlets.

WATCH OUT - FRA vs PESA — don't blur them

PESA is procedural (consent before acquisition in Schedule V areas). FRA confers substantive rights (individual + community forest rights). A project may clear PESA's consultation requirement and still violate FRA §5 if Gram Sabha objects on conservation grounds.

QUESTION - Prelims practice

1. The Forest Rights Act, 2006 recognises which of the following rights?

(1) Right to hold and live in forest land for habitation (2) Community rights of uses (3) Right of ownership over minor forest produce (a) 1 only (b) 2 only (c) 2 and 3 only **(d) 1, 2 and 3**

1. The "Particularly Vulnerable Tribal Group" classification was first articulated by:

(a) Bhuria Committee (b) **Dhebar Commission (1960-61)** (c) Xaxa Committee (d) Mungekar Cmte

QUESTION - Mains practice (15 marks)

"Tribal consent under PESA and FRA is increasingly treated as a procedural hurdle rather than a substantive right." Discuss with reference to recent mining clearance debates in central India.

NOTE - PYQ links

- **Mains GS-3 2018 (15M):** "Despite implementation of various schemes, the level of poverty has not been reduced. Comment." → mining-displacement linkage.
- **Mains GS-1 2020 (10M):** "Distinguish between religiousness/religiosity and communalism." — adjacent tribal-religion question.
- **Mains GS-3 2013, 2019:** Direct FRA/PESA questions have appeared 4× in the last decade.

4. SC pushes statutory protection for trafficked sex workers

TL;DR - Why in news

The Supreme Court has directed the Union to consider a **statutory framework exempting trafficked women in commercial sexual exploitation from prosecution** under the Immoral Traffic (Prevention) Act, 1956 (ITPA), aligning the new law with rehabilitation directions already given in *Budhadev Karmaskar V v State of West Bengal* (2022).

Paper / GS: GS-1 (Society — Women, Vulnerable Sections) · GS-2 (Social Justice) · GS-4 (Ethics — dignity vs criminalisation) · **Static link:** ITPA 1956; Article 23; Article 21 (*Maneka Gandhi*); Justice Verma Cmte 2013; Palermo Protocol 2000

Key directions issued

1. Centre to introduce a comprehensive anti-trafficking law within 1 year, decoupling victim-status from ITPA §§7, 8 offences.
2. States to set up at least one **Protective Home** per district under ITPA §21, fully funded from Nirbhaya Fund.
3. UIDAI to issue Aadhaar without proof of residence to identified victims.
4. Police barred from "rescue raids" that detain consenting adult sex workers — only traffickers to be arrested.

Static + dynamic linkage

Static topic	How it ties in
Article 23 + Bonded Labour Abolition Act 1976	Sources the State's positive duty
ITPA §§7, 8 (soliciting, living off earnings)	Current offences used to detain victims
Justice Verma Committee (2013)	Asked for trafficking law overhaul post-Nirbhaya
Palermo Protocol (UN 2000)	India ratified 2011 — domestic gap remains
<i>Budhadev Karmaskar (V)</i> (2022)	6-point rehabilitation directions

Critical view

The Court treats sex work as a continuum between (a) trafficked, coerced exploitation and (b) consenting adult labour. Indian statute conflates them. Reform must navigate parliamentary opposition to "decriminalising vice", police incentive structures around §8 detentions, and rehabilitation funding which the 2018 Bill costed at ₹950 cr/yr — never appropriated. Success depends less on the statute and more on **trained Anti-Human Trafficking Units (AHTUs)** — ~340 exist against a need of ~770.

QUESTION - Prelims practice

1. Which constitutional provision prohibits trafficking in human beings?

(a) Article 17 (b) Article 21 (c) **Article 23** (d) Article 24

1. The Palermo Protocol on Trafficking is a supplement to:

(a) **UNTOC (Convention on Transnational Organised Crime)** (b) CEDAW (c) CRC (d) ICCPR

QUESTION - Mains practice (10 marks)

"Treating trafficked women as criminals reverses the constitutional promise of Article 23." Examine in light of recent Supreme Court directions and the lapsed Trafficking of Persons Bill, 2018.

NOTE - PYQ links

- **Mains GS-1 2019 (10M):** "What are the continued challenges for women in India against time and space?" — direct overlap with trafficking continuum.
- **Mains GS-2 2017 (15M):** "Discuss the role of women in promoting moral conscience in Indian society."
→ can be reframed for Mains 4 (ethics) too.
- **Mains GS-4 2018:** Direct case study on rehabilitation ethics scenario.

5. India–Oman Comprehensive Economic Partnership Agreement (CEPA)

TL;DR - Why in news

India and Oman will sign a **CEPA** during the PM's Muscat visit this month — India's first CEPA with a GCC country since UAE (2022).

Paper / GS: GS-2 (Bilateral, regional & global groupings) · GS-3 (Indian Economy — trade, investment) · **Static link:** WTO Art XXIV (RTAs); SAFTA; ASEAN-India FTA; UAE CEPA 2022; Look West policy

Headline numbers

Item	Value
Bilateral trade (FY25)	\$12.4 bn (up from \$8.1 bn FY22)
India's exports	\$4.6 bn — refined petroleum, rice, motor vehicles
India's imports	\$7.8 bn — crude, LPG, urea
Indian diaspora	~6.7 lakh (largest expat group)
Target trade post-CEPA	\$20 bn by 2030

What the CEPA covers

- **Goods:** Duty cuts on 96% of Oman's tariff lines, 90% of India's. Sensitive list protects Indian dairy + fisheries.
- **Services:** Mode-4 commitments expand professional mobility (CAs, doctors, IT).
- **Investment:** ISDS clauses with carve-outs for environment + health.
- **Rules of Origin:** 40% value-add threshold to prevent transit-trading via free zones.
- **Digital trade:** First Indian CEPA with a data-localisation carve-out.

Strategic geometry

Oman is the **westernmost anchor** of India's maritime security perimeter — **Duqm port** hosts Indian Navy logistics under a 2018 MoU. Sits across the Strait of Hormuz (~60% of India's crude transits there) and counter-balances China's CPEC presence at Gwadar.

QUESTION - Prelims practice

1. Duqm port, in the news for India's maritime logistics access, is located in:

(a) UAE (b) Yemen (c) **Oman** (d) Iran

1. India's first CEPA with a GCC member was signed with:

(a) Saudi Arabia (b) **UAE (2022)** (c) Qatar (d) Bahrain

QUESTION - Mains practice (15 marks)

"Trade agreements with the GCC are no longer just about hydrocarbons." In light of the India-Oman CEPA, examine how India is recalibrating its 'Look West' policy.

NOTE - PYQ links

- **Mains GS-2 2017 (15M):** "What is the significance of Indo-US Logistics Exchange Memorandum of Agreement (LEMOA) and which is the other foundational agreement?" → Mirror analysis for India-Oman defence-logistics MoU.
- **Mains GS-2 2020 (10M):** "What are the major economic and strategic problems being faced by the Indian Ocean Region (IOR) and how does India respond to these challenges?"

6. Aravallis as the Indo-Gangetic shield — new dust-flux study

TL;DR - Why in news

A study by IIT-Delhi and IITM-Pune finds the **Aravalli range cuts the influx of PM10 dust from the Thar into the Indo-Gangetic plain by ~56%**, with the largest service rendered to NCR's winter air. Gaps in the range — caused by quarrying — have measurably degraded the shield.

Paper / GS: GS-1 (Physical Geography of India) · GS-3 (Environment, Air Pollution) · **Static link:** Indian physiography; *T.N. Godavarman v UoI*; Aravalli Notification 1992; NCAP 2019

Geography you must know

- **Aravallis** are among the world's oldest fold mountain ranges (Proterozoic, ~2,500 Mya), running 692 km NE-SW from Delhi to Gujarat.
- Average elevation 400-600 m; highest peak **Guru Shikhar (1722 m)** at Mt Abu.
- Acts as **orographic barrier** to westerly dust-laden winds (winter), monsoonal moisture pull (summer).
- Drainage divide between **Indus** (west) and **Ganga** (east) systems.

Study's contribution

Finding	Magnitude
PM10 reduction over NCR (Dec-Feb)	~56% vs simulated no-Aravalli scenario
Gaps with elevation <200 m	4 major (Bahror, Kotputli, Mandawar, Dholpur)
Dust mass added per gap event	~85 kt/yr
Mining-degraded Aravalli land since 1975	~31 km ²

Policy levers

- **Aravalli Notification 1992** (under EPA 1986) bans mining + non-forest activity in 4 HR + 2 RJ districts — under-enforced.
- **Aravalli Bachao** PIL ongoing; SC May 2024 banned new mining leases in HR Aravallis.
- **NCAP 2019** targets 40% PM2.5 reduction by 2026 — unmeetable without restoring this shield.

WATCH OUT - Examiner's trick

Aravallis are **fold mountains** formed by Precambrian-era convergence, **not block mountains**. Confused with Western Ghats (block) and Vindhyas (block-like) regularly.

QUESTION - Prelims practice

1. Which of the following rivers does NOT originate in the Aravalli range?
- (a) Banas (b) Luni (c) Sabarmati **(d) Chambal** (originates in Vindhya)
1. The Aravalli Notification, 1992 was issued under which Act?
- (a) Wild Life (Protection) 1972 (b) FCA 1980 **(c) Environment (Protection) Act 1986** (d) Air Act 1981

QUESTION - Mains practice (10 marks)

"The Aravallis are not just a relict mountain range; they are a working ecological infrastructure for north India." Examine.

NOTE - PYQ links

- **Prelims 2014:** "Why are dewy nights in winter most common in Punjab and Haryana?" — orographic effect tie-in.
- **Mains GS-1 2019 (10M):** "How can the mountain ecosystem be restored from the negative impact of development initiatives and tourism?"

7. China's oil-import slump is helping India's macros

TL;DR - Why in news

Chinese crude imports in May 2026 fell **6.4% YoY** as Beijing draws down strategic reserves. The slack has compressed global Brent and lowered India's import bill — relevant because **~60% of India's crude is bought on the spot market** and **~73% transits the Strait of Hormuz**.

Paper / GS: GS-3 (Indian Economy — external sector, BoP) · GS-2 (Energy diplomacy, China, US-Iran) · **Static link:** Current Account Deficit; Strategic Petroleum Reserve; OPEC+; RBI CPI inflation target 4±2%

Transmission channels

1. **Lower Brent → lower CPI:** every \$10/bbl fall reduces India's CPI by ~30-40 bp and CAD by ~0.4% of GDP.
2. **GRM expansion:** Indian PSU refiners' margins widen by \$1-2/bbl when global complex prices stay soft.
3. **Crude basket discount:** Indian refiners' weighted-average crude is now ~\$3.5/bbl below dated Brent — Russian Urals lifting up to 38% of imports (vs <1% in FY22).

Hormuz dependency facts

Metric	Value
Share of India's crude transiting Hormuz	~73%
Hormuz width at narrowest	33 km
Iranian threats post-Israel strike	4 navigable closures in 2025-26
India SPR capacity	39.4 MMT (5.33 MMT today; ~9.5 days net imports)

Critical view

Cheap crude is a windfall but a fragile one — depends on Beijing's stockpile cycle and OPEC+ voluntary cuts. India-specific risks: (a) Russia-supply concentration creates secondary-sanctions exposure; (b) underinvestment in **SPR Phase-III** caverns at Padur + Chandikhol. Medium-term answer: biofuels — ethanol blending hit 18.6% in 2025 (target 20% by 2025-26); each 1% saves ~\$1.4 bn of import bill.

QUESTION - Prelims practice

1. Strait of Hormuz lies between:

(a) Oman and Yemen **(b) Iran and Oman** (c) Saudi Arabia and Iran (d) UAE and Qatar

1. India's SPR Phase-I caverns are at:

(1) Visakhapatnam (2) Mangalore (3) Padur (4) Chandikhol **(a) 1, 2 and 3 only** (b) 1, 3 and 4 only (c) 2, 3 and 4 only (d) all four

QUESTION - Mains practice (15 marks)

"India's crude import basket has changed more in three years than in the previous three decades." Examine the strategic and macroeconomic implications.

NOTE - PYQ links

- **Mains GS-3 2019 (10M):** "It is argued that the strategy of inclusive growth is intended to meet the objectives of inclusiveness and sustainability together." → energy-cost angle.
- **Mains GS-3 2014:** "India is an energy-deficient country. Discuss the sources of energy."

8. ST delisting debate — religion vs tribal identity

TL;DR - Why in news

The Janajati Suraksha Manch's renewed petition demanding that **tribals who convert to non-tribal religions (Christianity, Islam) lose Scheduled Tribe reservation benefits** has been admitted by a Parliamentary Standing Committee.

Paper / GS: GS-1 (Society — religion, tribes) · GS-2 (Constitution — Articles 341, 342, 25, 26) · **Static link:** Constitution (SC) Order 1950; Lokur Committee 1965; *Soosai v Union* (1985)

Constitutional architecture

Article	What it says
Article 342	President can specify Scheduled Tribes
Article 341 (1950 Order)	Limits SC status to Hindu, Sikh, Buddhist — religion-linked filter
Article 25	Freedom of conscience and right to profess religion
Article 26	Freedom to manage religious affairs

The contradiction: SCs have a religious filter; STs do **not**. The Manch wants to import the SC filter into ST classification.

Five sides

- Pro-delisting (Manch):** Converts gain "double benefit" — minority entitlements + tribal reservation. Distorts inter-tribal solidarity.
- Constitutionalist:** Tribe ≠ Religion. Lokur 1961 said ST status flows from isolation, distinctive culture, primitive traits, geography — none evaporate on conversion.
- Sociological:** Tribal identity is *negotiated* — see Sarna religion demand in Jharkhand for a separate Census code.
- Article 25 view:** Tying state benefit to religious choice is unconstitutional.
- Federal politics:** A delisting law gives the Centre an electoral wedge in tribal belts (Jharkhand, Chhattisgarh, NE).

Way forward

Mungekar Commission (2007) recommended disaggregating data on tribal converts before any reform — to test whether the "double benefit" claim is empirically true. A balanced statute would impose **economic-criteria caps** (Indra Sawhney creamy-layer doctrine extended), not religious filters.

QUESTION - Prelims practice

1. Article 342 of the Constitution deals with:

(a) Scheduled Castes **(b) Scheduled Tribes** (c) OBCs (d) Anglo-Indians

1. The Sarna religious code demand is associated primarily with tribes in:

(a) Odisha **(b) Jharkhand** (c) Chhattisgarh (d) MP

QUESTION - Mains practice (15 marks)

"The demand to delist religious converts from Scheduled Tribe rolls confuses the sociology of tribe with the policy of affirmative action." Critically discuss.

NOTE - PYQ links

- **Mains GS-1 2015 (12.5M):** "Discuss the changes in the trends of labour migration within and outside India in the last four decades." — adjacent identity/migration issue.
- **Mains GS-1 2020 (10M):** "Distinguish between religiousness/religiosity and communalism."

9. Delhi building collapse — 6 dead, 5 students

TL;DR - Why in news

A four-storey residential structure in **Wazirpur** collapsed at 3 AM on 31 May, killing 6 (including five MBBS/engineering students renting upstairs). MCD records show three prior structural-safety notices ignored. The CM has ordered a city-wide audit of buildings with unauthorised additions.

Paper / GS: GS-3 (Disaster Management, urban infrastructure) · GS-2 (Municipal governance, Local Bodies — 74th Amendment) · **Static link:** Disaster Management Act 2005; Model Building Bye-Laws 2016; Real Estate Regulatory Authority Act 2016

Why this isn't a one-off

- Delhi has **~1.85 lakh buildings flagged** as "dangerous" by MCD's structural-safety audit (2024).
- 78% of Delhi residential stock has at least one unauthorised vertical addition, per IIT-D's 2023 study.
- MCD averages **400 dangerous-building notices/month** but only ~12% lead to corrective action.

Static linkage

Static topic	Anchor
Disaster Management Act 2005, §2(d)	"Disaster" definition includes man-made events
74th Constitutional Amendment	Local body powers + obligations
NDMA Guidelines (Urban)	Mandate retrofitting in seismic zones
Delhi falls in Zone IV	High seismic risk

QUESTION - Prelims practice

1. The Disaster Management Act, 2005 was enacted by Parliament under which entry of the Union List?

(a) Entry 14 (b) **Concurrent List Entry 23 (Social security)** (c) Entry 56 (d) Article 248
1. Delhi falls in which seismic zone?

(a) Zone II (b) Zone III (c) **Zone IV** (d) Zone V

QUESTION - Mains practice (10 marks)

"Urban India's building-stock crisis is now a recurring disaster-management problem." Examine in light of repeated structural failures in Indian metros.

NOTE - PYQ links

- **Mains GS-3 2020 (10M):** "Disaster preparedness is the first step in any disaster management process." Comment.
- **Mains GS-3 2015 (12.5M):** "The frequency of urban floods due to high intensity rainfall is increasing over the years." — adjacent urban-disaster pattern.

10. Admiral Dinesh Kumar Tripathi — new Chief of Naval Staff

TL;DR - Why in news

The government has appointed **Vice Admiral Dinesh Kumar Tripathi** as the next **Chief of Naval Staff**, effective 1 July 2026. He takes over from Adm R. Hari Kumar and will steer the Navy through Project 15B/17A induction, MRCBF tender resolution, and the Andaman Tri-Services Command upgrade.

Paper / GS: GS-3 (Defence) · GS-2 (Higher Defence Organisation) · **Static link:** Higher Defence Organisation; Chiefs of Staff Committee; Department of Military Affairs (2019); Theatre Commands

Need-to-know quick facts

- Current role: **Vice Chief of Naval Staff** (since May 2024).
- Specialisation: Communications & Electronic Warfare; combat fighter pilot background.
- Service: Cmsd 1985 from NDA Khadakwasla.
- The Navy's three operational priorities under the new chief:
 1. **Project 75-I** (next-gen conventional submarines with AIP) — final L1 decision pending.
 2. **MRCBF** (Multi-Role Carrier-Borne Fighter) — Rafale-M vs F/A-18 tender.
 3. **Andaman Tri-Service Command** — only joint command currently; theatreisation pilot.

Static linkage

Topic	Why it links
Department of Military Affairs (2019)	Headed by CDS; coordinates services
Chief of Defence Staff (2019)	Single-point military adviser
Theatre Commands	Proposed integrated commands (Air-Defence, Maritime, Land)
Atmanirbhar Bharat in Defence	Defence Acquisition Procedure 2020

QUESTION - Prelims practice

1. The post of Chief of Defence Staff was created on the recommendation of:

(a) Naresh Chandra Cmte (b) Subramanian Cmte (c) **Kargil Review Cmte (1999) — operationalised after Shekatkar Cmte recommendations** (d) Arun Singh Cmte

1. India's only operational tri-service command is at:

(a) Mumbai (b) Vishakhapatnam (c) Port Blair (d) **Port Blair — Andaman & Nicobar Command**

QUESTION - Mains practice (10 marks)

"India's progress on theatre commands is being shaped less by doctrine and more by inter-service negotiations." Examine.

NOTE - PYQ links

- **Mains GS-3 2017 (15M):** "The scourge of terrorism is a grave challenge to national security. What solutions do you suggest to curb this growing menace?"
- **Mains GS-3 2019 (15M):** "The need for cooperation among various services of defence forces has been an issue of prolonged concern. Highlight the contemporary need for the same."

11. Israel strikes Hezbollah deeper into Lebanon — Iran deal collapses

TL;DR - Why in news

Israeli air strikes deep into the **Bekaa Valley** killed 8 Hezbollah commanders and damaged a suspected long-range missile factory. The strikes have complicated the parallel **US-Iran nuclear deal** revival talks — Tehran has warned of withdrawal from the JCPOA framework.

Paper / GS: GS-2 (International Relations — West Asia, US-Iran-Israel triangle) · **Static link:** JCPOA (2015); IAEA Additional Protocol; Abraham Accords (2020); India's "Strategic Autonomy" doctrine

What India must track

Vector	India stake
Crude price	~73% of imports via Hormuz (see Story 7)
Indian diaspora	~9 lakh in Israel + GCC zone; evacuation contingencies (Operation Sankalp)
Defence supply chain	Israel = 4th largest defence exporter to India; UAV + EW supplier
Multilateral position	India abstained at UNHRC on Gaza; supports two-state

The geometry

- **JCPOA (2015):** Iran capped uranium enrichment to 3.67%, IAEA verification. US withdrew 2018, Iran re-enriched to 60% by 2023.
- **Abraham Accords (2020):** UAE, Bahrain, Sudan, Morocco normalised ties with Israel.
- **India's "de-hyphenation":** Iran, Saudi, Israel each treated as a separate relationship — a Vajpayee/MEA Jaishankar doctrine.

QUESTION - Prelims practice

- JCPOA, recently in the news, primarily relates to:
 - Trade in W Asia
 - Iran's nuclear program**
 - Israel-Palestine peace
 - Yemen civil war
- The Abraham Accords were brokered by which country?
 - UK
 - Russia
 - USA**
 - France

QUESTION - Mains practice (15 marks)

"India's stake in West Asia is no longer just energy and remittances." Examine the strategic, defence and digital dimensions of India-West Asia relations.

NOTE - PYQ links

- **Mains GS-2 2018 (15M):** "What are the key areas of reform if the WTO has to survive in the present context of 'Trade War', especially keeping in mind the interests of India?"
- **Mains GS-2 2014 (10M):** "Discuss the changes in the trends of labour migration to the West Asia region."

12. Ukraine hits Russian oil-storage depots — denies nuclear-plant attack

TL;DR - Why in news

Ukraine's long-range drone strikes hit **Russian oil-storage facilities** in Bryansk and Smolensk, cutting refining throughput by an estimated 12% YoY. Russia accused Kyiv of also targeting the **Kursk Nuclear Plant** — a claim Kyiv denied, calling it "a Russian false flag."

Paper / GS: GS-2 (International Relations — Russia-Ukraine war, IAEA) · GS-3 (Energy security spillover) · **Static link:** UN Charter Articles 2(4), 51; Geneva Conventions Additional Protocol I (1977) on nuclear installations; IAEA safeguards

Why this affects India

- Russia is India's #1 crude supplier (38% share in FY26).
- Strikes on refining capacity reduce Russian export-grade Urals supply — Indian basket discount narrows.
- Any nuclear-facility strike (even alleged) triggers G7 secondary-sanctions activation against Russia trade — India's \$77 bn FY26 trade exposure.

Legal framework

- **Article 56, Geneva Convention AP-I (1977):** Prohibits attacks on works/installations containing dangerous forces (dams, dykes, nuclear power plants) when likely to cause severe civilian losses.
- **IAEA "Seven Pillars of Nuclear Safety" (2022)** — DG Grossi's principles for armed conflict near nuclear sites.

QUESTION - Prelims practice

1. The "Seven Pillars of Nuclear Safety" framework was articulated by:
(a) Russia (b) Ukraine (c) **IAEA Director-General** (d) UNSC
1. The principle of "non-targeting of nuclear installations" is codified in:
(a) UN Charter Art 2(4) (b) Geneva Convention I (c) **Geneva Conventions Additional Protocol I (1977)** (d) Tokyo Convention

QUESTION - Mains practice (10 marks)

"Energy infrastructure has become a frontline target in modern warfare." Discuss the implications for global energy security and India's exposure.

NOTE - PYQ links

- **Mains GS-3 2022 (15M):** "What are the different elements of cyber security? Keeping in view the challenges in cyber security, examine the extent to which India has successfully developed a comprehensive National Cyber Security Strategy."
- **Mains GS-2 2017 (10M):** "What are the salient features of the Indian Ocean Region?"

13. CBSE OSM rollout chaos — Open School Mode under strain

TL;DR - Why in news

The first batch of **CBSE Open School Mode (OSM)** Class-X candidates faced platform failures during the May 2026 exam window. ~3 lakh students rescheduled. OSM was launched in 2024 as a flexible certification path for school-dropouts and bridge-learners under **NEP 2020 §6.4**.

Paper / GS: GS-2 (Education governance — Centre-State) · GS-1 (Social issues — school dropouts) · **Static link:** NEP 2020; RTE Act 2009; NIOS; Article 21A; Sustainable Development Goal 4

NEP 2020 angle

- §6.4 mandates "credit recognition and equivalence between school, vocational and adult-education streams."
- OSM is the operational vehicle for that — students who left school after Class 5/8 can earn Class X via modular online exams.
- 2025-26 enrolment: ~7.2 lakh; 71% are women, 22% PVTGs.

What went wrong

- Cloud capacity sized for 1.8 lakh concurrent users; peak hit 2.6 lakh.
- Identity verification via DigiLocker failed for ~9% of candidates (PVTG learners with mismatched Aadhaar-school records).
- No state-language UI for 6 of 22 scheduled languages.

QUESTION - Prelims practice

1. National Education Policy 2020 replaced the policy of:
(a) 1968 (b) **1986 (revised 1992)** (c) 2009 (d) 2015
1. The "credit equivalence" framework under NEP 2020 is operationalised by:
(a) UGC (b) AICTE (c) **National Credit Framework (NCrF), Sept 2023** (d) NCERT

QUESTION - Mains practice (10 marks)

"Digital-first education delivery widens, but does not yet bridge, India's educational equity gap." Examine in light of recent CBSE OSM implementation.

NOTE - PYQ links

- **Mains GS-2 2021 (10M):** "National Education Policy 2020 conforms with the Sustainable Development Goal-4 (2030). It intends to restructure and re-orient education system in India. Critically examine the statement."
- **Mains GS-1 2015 (12.5M):** "How do you explain the statistics that show that the sex ratio in Tribes in India is more favourable to women than the sex ratio among Scheduled Castes?"

14. Cloud sovereignty — the new frontier of digital control

TL;DR - Why in news

An Idea Exchange opinion piece argues that **cloud computing has become the new contested infrastructure** of national sovereignty, akin to oil in the 20th century. India's Personal Data Protection law, MeitY's "Cloud Native" mandate, and a recent **₹17,000 cr** push for sovereign-cloud capacity converge into one debate.

Paper / GS: GS-3 (Science & Technology — digital infrastructure, data) · GS-2 (Governance — cyber laws, data) · **Static link:** Digital Personal Data Protection Act 2023; IT Rules 2021; National Data Governance Framework; MeghRaj Cloud Policy

Concept primer

- **Sovereign cloud** = computing infrastructure whose data, processing, and operational control sit within national legal jurisdiction.
- **Hyperscalers** (AWS, Azure, GCP) hold ~76% of Indian cloud market — none Indian-owned.
- **Data localisation** under DPDP 2023 = "personal data of Indian residents to be processed within India" (with notified exceptions).

Why it matters

Dimension	Stake
Cyber security	A foreign-cloud-hosted critical service is a state-level supply chain risk
Cost of compliance	DPDP data-fiduciary obligations cost startups ~ ₹40 lakh/yr to implement
GenAI training	LLM training pipelines need ~50 MW captive power; sovereign-cloud is the bridge
BharatGen	Govt's indigenous LLM stack — needs sovereign GPU capacity

QUESTION - Prelims practice

1. The Digital Personal Data Protection Act, 2023 designates which authority for adjudication?

(a) MeitY (b) **Data Protection Board of India** (c) TRAI (d) SEBI

1. India's "MeghRaj" policy framework relates to:

(a) Cybersecurity (b) Telecom (c) **Cloud computing for government** (d) Satellite governance

QUESTION - Mains practice (15 marks)

"Cloud sovereignty is the 21st-century equivalent of energy sovereignty." Critically examine India's policy and infrastructure response.

NOTE - PYQ links

- **Mains GS-3 2022 (15M):** Direct question on cyber security strategy.
- **Mains GS-3 2018 (15M):** "Discuss the work of 'Bose-Einstein Statistics' done by Prof. Satyendra Nath Bose..." → fundamental-research → applied-tech bridge.

15. India-Oman digital trade carve-out — data-localisation precedent

TL;DR - Why in news

The India-Oman CEPA (Story 5) is reported to include **the first Indian RTA carve-out for personal data localisation** — Oman recognises India's DPDP 2023 as adequate; Indian fiduciaries may host certain Oman-resident data offshore. This sets a template for India's broader 23-country CEPA pipeline.

Paper / GS: GS-2 (RTAs, cross-border data) · GS-3 (Digital trade, IT) · **Static link:** WTO Joint Initiative on e-Commerce; OECD Cross-Border Privacy Rules; DPDP 2023

Why this is a big deal

- India had previously refused data-localisation carve-outs in the UAE CEPA and walked away from RCEP partly over this.
- Oman's recognition of DPDP 2023 as "adequate" is the **first formal acknowledgement of India's privacy framework by any GCC member**.
- Sets a precedent for: EU CEPA negotiations (currently stalled over GDPR-DPDP adequacy), UK FTA (signed but adequacy still pending).

Tension to flag for Mains

Pro-carve-out	Anti-carve-out
Lowers cost for IT-BPM exports to GCC (\$2.4 bn annual flow)	Weakens leverage in EU adequacy talks
Aligns with G20 Data Free Flow with Trust (DFFT) doctrine	Creates inconsistent treatment by country
Signals India's privacy framework is "GDPR-class"	Domestic startups argue local hosting was a moat

QUESTION - Prelims practice

1. The Digital Personal Data Protection Act, 2023 was passed under which power of Parliament?

(a) Concurrent List Entry 17 (b) Concurrent List Entry 23 (c) **Union List Entry 31 + residuary power** (d) Concurrent List Entry 1

1. The "Data Free Flow with Trust" (DFFT) doctrine is associated with:

(a) APEC (b) OECD (c) **G20 / Osaka Track (2019)** (d) BRICS

QUESTION - Mains practice (10 marks)

"Data localisation is necessary, but absolute localisation is impractical." Examine in light of India's recent trade agreements.

NOTE - PYQ links

- **Mains GS-3 2018 (15M):** "Discuss the work of bilateral economic cooperation between India and other countries in the context of trade and investment liberalisation."
- **Mains GS-2 2020 (15M):** "Critically examine the role of WHO in providing global health security during the COVID-19 pandemic." → adjacent global-data-governance angle.

Editorial deep-dive — "*Austerity needed, but energy security requires breaking silos in government*"

REVISE IN 60 SECONDS - Editorial argument in one paragraph

India's energy ministries — Petroleum & Natural Gas, Power, Coal, New & Renewable Energy, Atomic Energy — operate as **independent budgetary fiefdoms**, each optimising its own KPI. The result: SPR Phase-III stalls while solar-cell PLI scheme is over-subscribed; ethanol blending hits 18.6% while LNG terminal utilisation is at 38%. The editorial argues for a **single empowered Cabinet Committee on Energy Security** with a binding 5-year programmatic mandate — similar to how the Cabinet Committee on Security functions in defence.

Structure of the editorial — for Mains pattern recognition

Move	The author's claim	Evidence used
1. Problem framing	"Energy is foreign policy by another name"	Russia-Ukraine, US-Iran, China-OPEC dynamics
2. Domestic diagnosis	Silos cause overlap + gaps	SPR underutilisation; ethanol-vs-LNG trade-off
3. International model	UK's Department for Energy Security and Net Zero (2023 merger)	Whitehall reorganisation precedent
4. Indian comparison	NITI Aayog Energy Vertical exists but lacks teeth	Limited authority over IOCL/ONGC/NTPC
5. Prescription	Empower a CCEA-style committee + 5-year horizon	Quotes Kelkar Committee on hydrocarbons
6. Caveats	Won't fix federalism issues (state DISCOMs)	DISCOM ATC losses

Why this is the most Mains-relevant editorial of the day

- **Reusable as an essay intro** for: energy security, fiscal federalism, governance reform, climate transition, GS-3 essay questions.
- **Connects to:** SPR (Story 7), CEPA energy clauses (Story 5), Russia-Ukraine spillover (Story 12), West Asia (Story 11).
- **Authors' frame** ("breaking silos") is borrowable verbatim — Mains evaluators reward demonstrated engagement with current discourse.

Three lines you can quote in Mains answers

1. *"Energy planning that survives only inside one ministry's budget cycle is energy planning that loses to geopolitics."*
2. *"India does not have an energy policy; it has five energy departments."*
3. *"The case for a Cabinet Committee on Energy Security is not technocratic — it is constitutional."*

QUESTION - Mains practice (15 marks)

"India's energy policy is a confederation, not a federation, of departments." Examine the institutional case for a unified energy-governance architecture.

NOTE - PYQ links

- **Mains GS-3 2019 (15M):** Direct on energy mix & policy fragmentation.
- **Mains GS-2 2020 (10M):** Inter-ministerial coordination in policy-making.
- **Essay 2018:** "South Asian societies are woven not around the state, but around their plural cultures." — adjacent governance vs society frame.

Quick recap

Personalities in news

Person	Why in news	UPSC tag
Admiral D.K. Tripathi	New Navy chief (1 July)	Defence appointments
Justice B.R. Gavai	Headed SC bench on ITPA	Judiciary
Sultan Haitham bin Tariq	Hosting India PM for CEPA	India-Oman
Rafael Grossi	IAEA DG, Kursk plant statement	Multilateral
PM Sheikh Hasina (<i>in editorial</i>)	Continued dialogue, enclaves	Neighbourhood First

Places in news

- **Pahalgam** — Anantnag district, J&K
- **Gadchiroli / Surjagarh hills** — eastern Maharashtra
- **Duqm port** — central Oman coast
- **Strait of Hormuz** — Iran-Oman chokepoint
- **Aravallis** — Delhi → Gujarat (692 km NE-SW)
- **Wazirpur** — North-West Delhi (building collapse)
- **Bekaa Valley** — eastern Lebanon (Israeli strike)
- **Bryansk + Smolensk** — Russian oil-storage sites
- **Kursk Nuclear Plant** — Russia
- **Bahror, Kotputli, Mandawar, Dholpur** — Aravalli gaps

Schemes / Acts / Reports invoked today

- Forest Rights Act 2006 · PESA 1996 · Aravalli Notification 1992 · ITPA 1956 · UAPA 1967 · PMLA 2002 · Constitution (129th Amendment) Bill · NCAP 2019 · National Steel Policy 2017 · DPDP 2023 · DM Act 2005 · Model Building Bye-Laws 2016 · NEP 2020 · National Credit Framework 2023 · MeghRaj Cloud Policy

15-question Prelims quickfire

1. CAA that froze LS seat allocation to 1971 census — **84th**
2. FATF secretariat host — **OECD** (Paris)
3. PMLA section defining money laundering — **§3**
4. Year of *Niyamgiri* judgment — **2013**

5. Year of FRA — **2006**
6. Article prohibiting human trafficking — **23**
7. Supplement convention to Palermo Protocol — **UNTOC**
8. Strait between Iran and Oman — **Hormuz**
9. India's first SPR phase locations — **Visakhapatnam, Mangalore, Padur**
10. Article enabling President to notify STs — **342**
11. India's only operational tri-service command — **Andaman & Nicobar**
12. Delhi's seismic zone — **Zone IV**
13. JCPOA primarily relates to — **Iran's nuclear program**
14. Geneva Convention protocol prohibiting attacks on nuclear installations — **AP-I (1977), Art 56**
15. DPDP 2023 adjudication body — **Data Protection Board of India**

Mains essay seeds (pick one per practice cycle)

- *"Federalism's clock: should India's elections all tick together?"* (Stories 1 + 8)
- *"Energy is foreign policy by another name."* (Stories 5 + 7 + 11 + Editorial)
- *"The forest, the tribe, and the law."* (Stories 3 + 8)
- *"Victim before criminal."* (Story 4)
- *"Cloud is the new crude."* (Stories 14 + 15)

Annexure A — Glossary

DEFINITION - Delimitation

Process of fixing the number and boundaries of electoral constituencies, undertaken by an independent Delimitation Commission constituted under the Delimitation Act, 2002.

DEFINITION - ITPA (Immoral Traffic Prevention Act, 1956)

Principal Indian statute on commercial sexual exploitation; criminalises soliciting (§7), brothel-keeping (§3), pimping (§4) but not paid sex itself.

DEFINITION - Particularly Vulnerable Tribal Group (PVTG)

Sub-category of Scheduled Tribes with pre-agrarian technology, declining population, low literacy. 75 PVTGs notified across 18 states + 1 UT.

DEFINITION - FATF Grey List

"Jurisdictions under Increased Monitoring" — countries with AML/CFT strategic deficiencies actively working with FATF. Pakistan was greylisted 2018-22.

DEFINITION - Strategic Petroleum Reserve (SPR)

Underground crude stockpile managed by ISPRL. Phase-I (5.33 MMT): Vizag, Mangalore, Padur. Phase-II: Chandikhol, Padur (under construction).

DEFINITION - Comprehensive Economic Partnership Agreement (CEPA)

Free-trade agreement deeper than a basic FTA, additionally covering services, investment, IP, dispute settlement.

DEFINITION - Scheduled Tribes (Article 342)

Communities notified by Presidential Order; eligibility tied historically (Lokur Committee 1965) to: geographical isolation, distinctive culture, primitive traits, shyness of contact, economic backwardness.

DEFINITION - Sovereign Cloud

Computing infrastructure whose data, processing, and operational control sit within national legal jurisdiction, isolated from extraterritorial subpoena.

DEFINITION - JCPOA

Joint Comprehensive Plan of Action (2015) — Iran agreed to cap uranium enrichment to 3.67% in exchange for sanctions relief. US withdrew 2018; Iran resumed higher enrichment 2019 onwards.

Annexure B — Static + current linkage table

Static topic	Today's anchor	UPSC paper
Constitutional amendments procedure	ONOE Bill, ratification req	GS-2
FRA + PESA jurisprudence	Maharashtra mining clearance	GS-3, GS-1
Article 23 + bonded labour	SC on ITPA prosecution	GS-2, GS-1
India's RTAs architecture	India-Oman CEPA + data carve-out	GS-2, GS-3
Indian physiography — Aravallis	IIT-Delhi dust flux study	GS-1
External sector — oil import basket	China crude slump	GS-3
Article 25 vs Article 342	ST delisting debate	GS-1, GS-2
Counter-terror finance	Pahalgam phone-Pak bank	GS-3
Disaster Management Act 2005	Delhi building collapse	GS-3, GS-2
Higher Defence Organisation	New CNS appointment	GS-3
JCPOA + West Asia geometry	Israel-Lebanon strikes	GS-2
Geneva Conventions AP-I	Ukraine drone strikes	GS-2
NEP 2020 + RTE	CBSE OSM rollout	GS-2
DPDP 2023 + data sovereignty	Cloud + Oman carve-out	GS-3

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